ON

September 10, the Election Commission of India (ECI) convened chief electoral officers from across the country to discuss the preparation of a nationwide Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, a bureaucratic exercise it insists is about "cleaning up" voter lists, but which critics say cuts to the core question: who counts as a citizen in India? The ECI had announced this initiative in June, and is already implementing it in poll-bound Bihar. Now it is beginning to move its levers to extend the exercise across India, before assembly elections scheduled early next year in five states. "The ECI is afraid the poll process would be misled by fake votes in the name of dead voters, permanently migrated voters, duplicate voters, fake and foreign voters," Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar had declared following the launch of the SIR in Bihar. "That is why this revision has been launched in Bihar and will be taken to the entire country. Should the Election Commission not weed out such voters?"

The Opposition sees this entire spell of electoral roll revision as a political weapon to eliminate citizens likely to vote against the ruling National Democratic Alliance (NDA) led by the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), especially in Bihar this year, and West Bengal and Assam next year. That feeling of unease grew when Prime Minister Narendra Modi, in his Independence Day address, declared he would launch a "high-powered demography mission" to weed out illegal immigrants. "Infiltrators are snatching away the livelihood of our youth [and] targeting the sisters and daughters of our country, misleading innocent tribals and capturing their land," he said from the ramparts of the Red Fort this August 15. The Opposition criticised Modi's latest mission as a ploy to cloak the electoral revision exercise in nationalistic rhetoric to quell voters' growing concerns about its true purpose. The Congress cleverly dovetailed Rahul Gandhi's 'vote *chori*' campaign into its wider attack on the omissions of the Commission, accusing the ECI of allegedly fixing electoral rolls to favour the ruling BJP.

The focal point of the Opposition's criticism is the ECI's document requirements for a citizen to prove he or she is an eligible voter in Bihar. The ECI is also executing such a detailed SIR in three months when in the past such revisions took close to two years and were never timed to meet an election deadline. On June 24 this year, the ECI gave 76.7 million eligible voters in Bihar a month to submit proof of Indian citizenship from a list of 11 acceptable documents. These included birth certificates, passports, matriculation certificates, land ownership papers, ID cards of a PSU employee, ID issued by a government body pre-July 1987, forest rights certificate, caste certificates, permanent resident certificates, family register or NRC where it exists. The list deliberately excluded the three forms of identification most commonly held by India's poor and marginalised populations: Aadhaar cards, voter ID cards issued by the ECI itself and ration cards. On September 8, the Supreme Court did order the inclusion of Aadhaar as a 12th acceptable document in Bihar, but it came with a catch: the ECI reserves the right to demand additional documentation to verify Aadhaar authenticity. Already, ECI sources report discrepancies in the documents of nearly 300,000 electors. The number of voters who may ultimately be removed from the rolls will not be known until the final list is released on September 30. Petitioners challenging the SIR in the Supreme Court accuse the ECI of procedural violations, lack of transparency and failure to follow its own rulebook. Yet they are not sure if they will find redress, since the courts have indicated the exercise will be quashed only if outright illegality is proven. Final arguments are scheduled for October 7.

Opposition parties allege that the ECI is exceeding its constitutional mandate, since citizenship determination is not within its purview. They characterise the revision as a calculated political strategy to benefit the BJP, particularly in Bihar, Assam and West Bengal, states with high Muslim populations of 17 per cent, 34 per cent and 27 per cent, respectively. Critics see these states as the immediate battleground where the definition of citizen-



"It's a deliberate conspiracy, the country's demography is being altered. It threatens the unity, integrity and progress of the country. The demography mission will deal with this severe crisis in a time-bound manner"

— NARENDRA MODI, *Prime Minister*